

SMALL BANK, BIG AMBITIONS

2006

Janalakshmi Financial was set up as a private limited company

2008

RBI grants NBFC licence to Janalakshmi; later, it is classified as an NBFC-MFI

2014

TPG Asia invests ₹248 crore in Janalakshmi

2015

Gets RBI approval to convert NBFC to small finance bank (SFB)

2016-2017

Caladium Investment puts in ₹370.5 crore; Bajaj Allianz Life Insurance, Bajaj Allianz General Insurance, ICICI Prudential Life Insurance invest

2018

HarbourVest Partners, ICICI Lombard General Insurance invest; Jana starts gold loans and SFB operations

2019-2020

Launches affordable housing loans; Amansa Holdings and Hero Enterprise Partner Ventures invest; crosses ₹10,000 crore in deposits in Sept 2020; launches two-wheeler loans

2023

Raises ₹560 crore from investors like Radhakishan Damani, Akash Bhanshali, Ashish Kacholia

2023

New investors like Dovetail, Deepak Talwar, Volrado, and Singularity invest ₹306 crore

2024

₹570-crore IPO subscribed close to 20 times; its stocks were priced at ₹690 on July 11, against the offer price of ₹414 per share

the guard escorting Kanwal suggested entering through the back entrance due to a protest by the employees' union. But he decided to take the front gate. Known as a "solution and growth manager", Kanwal quickly assessed the situation and devised a plan. Within six months as the Regional CEO for North East Asia, he suggested appointing a local CEO to improve communication and gain the trust of the employees. The strategy worked, and the bank soon turned around.

Kanwal, 58, could have secured another assignment with a foreign bank after he left StanChart in 2017, but he wanted to pursue something more entrepreneurial. "It was probably more me," he says, sitting in the headquarters of Jana Small Finance Bank—where he is MD & CEO—at Bengaluru's The Fairway Business Park. Shortly after leaving StanChart, he conducted due diligence on three NBFCs in India but decided not to go that way. Soon, Ajay Banga, who was President & CEO of Mastercard then, invited him to come on board as an advisor to handle the card network's relationships across Asia. Global private equity firm TPG also inducted him as an advisor to oversee three investee companies: Sri Lanka's Union Bank of Colombo, India's Jana Financial Services, and Indonesia's Bank BTPN.

Jana, originally known as Janalakshmi Financial Services, was a microfinance institution (MFI) that faced huge losses in 2016 due to demonetisation. The MFI, which was unable to win a universal banking licence in 2013, was founded by Ramesh Ramanathan, who had worked with Citibank in New York and London. Kanwal was tasked with finding solutions for Jana's post-demonetisation woes and preparing it for a small finance bank (SFB) licence.

In his advisory role, Kanwal